

Data Analyst

Do not advance

Candidate: Priya Nair

Date: 2026-08-13

Interview language: English

Executive summary

Priya Nair's résumé matches the profile of a retail data analyst, but her live interview answers failed to substantiate her technical depth in SQL and Python. She provided highly generic explanations of her automation and dashboarding work, and was unable to detail the specific metrics or analytical methods used in her stakeholder presentations.

Competency scorecard

COMPETENCY	RATING	JUSTIFICATION
SQL & Data Manipulation TECHNICAL	Weak	Priya was unable to provide any specific details regarding the SQL queries, joins, window functions, or pandas operations she used to automate the inventory reconciliation report, describing the process only in highly generic terms despite multiple follow-up questions.
BI & Dashboarding TECHNICAL	Adequate	She confirmed building a Looker dashboard with basic metrics like daily sales, profit, and losses by product, and explained that regional customization was limited to a data security layer restricting access.
Stakeholder Communication & Collaboration GENERAL	Weak	Although she confirmed presenting to the VP of Merchandising using custom slides, she failed to provide any specific metrics or data points when asked how she identified hot-selling items or justified her recommendation to increase production.

Strengths

- Confirmed experience presenting data to executive-level stakeholders (VP of Merchandising) using tailored slides alongside dashboards.
- Experience setting up basic data security layers in Looker to restrict regional data access.

Concerns

- Unable to explain or name any specific SQL functions, joins, window functions, or Python/pandas operations used in her previous automation projects.
- Failed to provide concrete metrics or data points when describing a major business recommendation she made to leadership.
- Did not cover key role requirements during the interview, such as A/B testing and statistics.

Résumé vs. interview — reality check

Priya's résumé claims significant achievements, such as automating an inventory report in Python (reducing manual time from 6 hours to 30 minutes) and driving a 12% conversion increase via A/B testing. However, during the interview, she could not explain the technical mechanics (SQL/pandas) behind the automation, and the A/B testing competency was not covered, leaving these major claims largely unsubstantiated.

Panel perspectives

Alex

Alex focused on the technical competencies (SQL, Python, and BI dashboarding). He found Priya's technical explanations highly generic, noting that she could not name any specific SQL or pandas functions used in her automation work, though she did adequately explain the security layer setup in Looker.

Sara

Sara focused on stakeholder communication. She confirmed that Priya has experience presenting to a VP using custom slides, but noted a critical lack of depth when Priya could not recall any specific metrics or data points used to support her business recommendations.

Both interviewers observed a consistent pattern: while Priya can describe her responsibilities at a high level (e.g., presenting to a VP, automating reports, setting up dashboards), she struggles to provide the specific technical details or data metrics that underpin her work. Alex's technical probing revealed a lack of depth in SQL and Python, which reinforces Sara's finding that Priya could not detail the metrics used in her executive presentations.

Recommendation & next steps

If the team chooses to proceed despite the lack of technical detail, a rigorous technical assessment focusing on SQL window functions and Python (pandas) data manipulation is highly recommended to verify her capabilities.

Full transcript

Q1. Hello. My name is Alex. Thank you for joining us today. We are here to discuss the Data Analyst position at Lumen Retail Analytics. My colleague, Sara, is also joining us for this interview.

(no answer recorded)

Q2. Hello. I am Sara. I handle people operations, and I am very pleased to meet you today. To begin, could you please share a brief overview of your background, and tell us what led you to apply for this role?

I have 5 years of data analyst experience and when i saw that job it actually related to my interest

Q3. Thank you for sharing that. Five years of experience in data analysis is a solid foundation. Since you mentioned this role aligns with your interests, I would like to understand your background a bit better. What specific types of business data or analytical problems have you focused on during your career?

I was focused solving HR related , Supply Chain related and Procurement related data

Q4. Thank you for explaining that. Having a background in supply chain and procurement data is very relevant. In this role, we help retail brands translate raw sales and inventory data into merchandising decisions. Could you share an example of how you have used supply chain or procurement data to help business stakeholders make a specific decision?

Well we have created power bi dashboards which helps them to track inventory day by day and take decisions with confidence

Q5. That is helpful context. Moving into the technical aspects of this role, I noticed on your résumé that you automated an inventory reconciliation report using Python, which reduced weekly manual processing time. Could you explain how you structured the SQL queries and data manipulation steps to achieve that automation? [SQL & Data Manipulation](#)

We created SQL queries based on business rules . and all the steps previously which are performed in excel are now performed automatically

“We created SQL queries based on business rules . and all the steps previously which are performed in excel are now performed automatically”

Q6. I understand that you transitioned those manual Excel steps into an automated process. To help me understand the technical complexity, could you describe the specific SQL joins or window functions you used, and how you utilized the pandas library in Python to handle that data? [SQL & Data Manipulation](#)

yes pandas libraries were used to read dataframes filter out and join the data and sql were mostly for the execution

“pandas libraries were used to read dataframes filter out and join the data and sql were mostly for the execution”

Q7. I understand that you used pandas for filtering and joining, and SQL for the initial execution. To help us understand the technical depth of this project, could you describe a specific challenge you encountered when reconciling these data sources, and the exact pandas or SQL functions you used to resolve it? SQL & Data Manipulation

Actually there were data from multiple data source like 30-40 the challenge was to unify them and in the end create a working data model with fact and dimensions, and in this way where pandas helped is cleaning the data and SQL helped in execution

“where pandas helped is cleaning the data and SQL helped in execution”

Q8. Managing thirty to forty different data sources to build a unified dimensional model is a significant undertaking. Looking at your experience with Brightfield Commerce, your résumé mentions that you partnered directly with the VP of Merchandising to present monthly business reviews. Could you describe a specific instance where you had to present a complex data finding to the VP, and how you structured your communication to ensure it was actionable? Stakeholder Communication & Collaboration

yes once i had to present a complex finding to VP I created separate slides for his understanding apart from dashboard , slides give info more about what is this data about how to read, and what does it mean

“I created separate slides for his understanding apart from dashboard , slides give info more about what is this data about how to read, and what does it mean”

Q9. Creating dedicated slides to break down complex metrics is a very thoughtful approach. Could you tell me what the specific finding was that you presented to the VP, and what actionable recommendation you made based on that data?

Stakeholder Communication & Collaboration

It was marketing data, based on the data we have to recommend increae of production of some products in one area as they were hot selling items

“recommend increae of production of some products in one area as they were hot selling items”

Q10. Thank you for explaining that. Recommending a production increase based on regional demand is a significant business decision. To help me understand how you guided the VP through this, what specific metrics or data points did you use to identify these hot-selling items? I would also be interested to hear how the VP responded to your recommendation. Stakeholder Communication & Collaboration

He was positive about my recommendation as I have given him proof of the sales with the historical data by area

“He was positive about my recommendation as I have given him proof of the sales with the historical data by area”

Q11. Understood. It is always rewarding when data-driven recommendations are well received by leadership. Let us move on to your experience with business intelligence tools. Your résumé mentions that you built and maintained a weekly merchandising dashboard in Looker for three regional teams, replacing a manual spreadsheet process. Could you tell me about the key metrics you included in that dashboard, and how you designed it to meet the needs of those different regional teams? *BI & Dashboarding*

Yes I included all important metrics in that which were needed to take decision like daily sales , profit , losses by product

“daily sales , profit , losses by product”

Q12. Those are indeed essential metrics for merchandising decisions. Since this dashboard was utilized by three different regional teams, could you explain how you designed the Looker dashboard to support their distinct regional requirements? *BI & Dashboarding*

first of all we have security layer over there everyone can access their own data other than that there was no more regional requirement discussed metrics and units were same so no more challenge in that area

“first of all we have security layer over there everyone can access their own data other than that there was no more regional requirement discussed”

Q13. Thank you very much for your time today. That concludes the questions I have prepared for this screening. Before we close, do you have any questions for me about the Data Analyst role, or about our company?

No I don't have any question

Q14. Thank you very much for your time today. I appreciate you sharing your experience with me. The hiring team will review our conversation and get back to you soon regarding the next steps. Thank you again, and have a pleasant day.

(no answer recorded)

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